against terror' to root out intolerance and radicalization from Pakistani society. A madrassa regulation board was also established for the regulation of the madrassa system (Lall 2009). A National Curriculum Policy 2006 as discussed in the next section was formulated to encourage critical thinking, and the responsibility of managing and monitoring schools was devolved to the districts (International Crisis Group 2004). Yet, Musharraf was forced to backtrack on many qualitative changes that aimed at de-Islamizing the curriculum to appease the religious right (International Crisis Group 2014a).

The PPP that emerged victorious in the 2008 elections continued with the reform efforts, introducing the National Education Policy 2009 that was being developed under Musharraf. The policy reemphasized the importance of Islam informing the 'social, cultural and moral values' that are inculcated through the education system, but also the need to 'ensure equal educational opportunities to all the citizens of Pakistan and to provide minorities with adequate facilities for their cultural and religious development, enabling them to participate effectively in the overall national effort' (Ministry of Education 2009, pp. 9, 18). However, such policies were far from being implemented in the education system. In 2010, the Eighteenth Amendment was introduced that devolved the authority to provide education from the federal to provincial governments.[3] Under the Sharif government the changes introduced by the provincial governments have varied, with most provinces following the National Curriculum of 2006, especially for citizenship education, that is, Social Studies and Pakistan Studies. The next section examines the curriculum for these subjects, and the changes that have been introduced to further contextualize the student narratives that follow.

Citizenship education, curriculum and the Pakistani youth

The role of citizenship education in promoting civic mindedness and responsibility towards the nation state, in facilitating social cohesion and multiculturalism is evident in countries from the United Kingdom to Canada, Australia and South Africa (see Keating et al. 2010; Whitely 2012; Niens and Chastenay 2008; Print 2005). In their study on citizenship education in Quebec and Northern Ireland, Niens and Chastenay (2008) highlight its importance in challenging social and religious divisions within society, but also its limitations in cases where the curriculum does not address the social, cultural and historical realities of its society (p. 535). Finkel and Ernst (2005) concluded that 'under the right pedagogical and "classroom climate" conditions, civic education can be an effective agent not only for increasing democratic values and skills, but also for